

The First Larut War (1861–1862) Reconsidered:

Reassessing the Water-Dispute Narrative Through Contemporaneous Colonial Evidence

A Historical Reconsideration Based on Contemporaneous Colonial Correspondence

By Ho Siew Khui 何小驹 (Hé Xiǎojū)

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Abstract

This study re-examines the commonly accepted water-dispute narrative surrounding the origins of the First Larut War through contemporaneous British Colonial Office correspondence relating to Larut and Perak during 1861–1862. Later historical summaries have frequently presented the conflict as arising after Hai San miners deliberately interfered with water supplies connected to Ghee Hin mining operations.

However, the surviving contemporaneous records suggest a more disputed evidential environment than many later simplified narratives imply. The correspondence preserves conflicting testimony, competing accounts regarding upstream and downstream mining positions, and uncertainty concerning how responsibility for the dispute was ultimately assigned.

The records also reveal that British officials simultaneously occupied investigative, adjudicative and protective roles within the dispute while repeatedly referring to Ghee Hin miners connected to the conflict as British subjects recruited from Penang. These overlapping institutional roles raise important historiographical questions regarding neutrality and evidential interpretation.

Rather than seeking to establish the definitive innocence or guilt of either faction, this study argues that the surviving contemporaneous evidence may not support the degree of certainty later historical narratives often assign to the traditional water-dispute explanation for the outbreak of the First Larut War.

Keywords: First Larut War; 1861; 1862; Larut; Perak; Hai San; Ghee Hin; mining water disputes; British Malaya; Colonial Office records; contemporaneous evidence; historiography; hydrological dispute; colonial administration.

Sources and Methodology

This study is based primarily upon contemporaneous British colonial correspondence within the Colonial Office (CO) records relating to Larut, Perak and the Straits Settlements during the disturbances of 1861–1862.

All CO references in this paper refer to records held at The National Archives (United Kingdom), Colonial Office series. The records examined were accessed through the Gale Primary Sources platform. Researchers should note that Gale image numbering may differ from the original pagination or folio numbering of the archival records.

The archival material examined includes administrative correspondence, witness testimony, petitions, compensation discussions, official memoranda and reports relating to the Larut disturbances and mining-water dispute.

Particular reliance has been placed upon material within CO 273/5 concerning:

- allegations relating to interference with mining water supplies,
- disputes between Hai San and Ghee Hin mining groups,
- British administrative responses,
- compensation claims,
- and correspondence involving Perak authorities and British officials connected to Penang and the Straits Settlements.

This study focuses specifically upon the evidential and historiographical problems surrounding the commonly repeated water-dispute narrative associated with the outbreak of the First Larut War.

The methodology adopted involves close comparison between later historical summaries and the surviving contemporaneous Colonial Office correspondence. Particular attention has been given to:

- conflicting testimony preserved within the records,
- unresolved questions concerning upstream and downstream mining positions,
- the absence of clearly surviving technical or adjudicative determinations,
- and the institutional role occupied by British authorities within the broader dispute-resolution process.

Rather, it reassesses whether later historical certainty regarding sole Hai San responsibility is fully supported by the surviving contemporaneous evidence.

Introduction

The origins of the First Larut War are commonly presented in later historical summaries as arising after Hai San miners allegedly interfered with the water supply of Ghee Hin mining operations in Larut.¹ Over time, this explanation became one of the most widely repeated narratives concerning the outbreak of the conflict.

However, contemporaneous Colonial Office correspondence from 1861–1862 suggests that the surviving evidence may be less definitive than many later retellings imply.² The records preserve conflicting testimony, disputed hydrological claims and overlapping institutional roles within the dispute-resolution process.³

This paper re-examines whether the surviving contemporaneous evidence supports the later historical claim that the Hai San were solely responsible for triggering the dispute through deliberate interference with Ghee Hin water supplies.

Historical Background

The First Larut War refers to disturbances occurring in Larut, Perak, during 1861–1862 between rival Chinese secret-society groups associated with the rapidly expanding tin-mining industry. Later historical accounts generally identify the principal factions as the Hai San and the Ghee Hin societies, both of which possessed extensive mining and labour networks connected to Penang and the western Malay Peninsula.⁴

By the mid-nineteenth century, Larut had emerged as one of the most economically important tin-producing districts in Perak. Mining operations depended heavily upon access to water for ore extraction and processing. Control over rivers, canals and mining-water systems therefore carried major economic significance, particularly where multiple mining settlements operated in close proximity.⁵

Later historical narratives commonly describe the origins of the First Larut War as arising after Hai San miners allegedly interfered with water supplies connected to Ghee Hin mining operations, thereby triggering retaliatory violence and broader disturbances throughout Larut. Over time, this explanation became one of the dominant summaries of the conflict within later historiography.⁶

The surviving Colonial Office correspondence presents a more contested picture. The records preserve conflicting testimony, competing accounts regarding upstream and downstream mining positions, and unresolved questions concerning how responsibility for the dispute was ultimately determined.

The Water Dispute and the Problem of Historical Certainty

Modern summaries of the First Larut War frequently state that Hai San miners cut or diverted water channels supplying Ghee Hin mining operations, thereby triggering the conflict.

The contemporaneous Colonial Office records present a more disputed evidential picture. While British correspondence from 1861 records allegations that Hai San miners interfered with water connected to Ghee Hin mining activity, the same records also preserve conflicting testimony, disputed explanations and competing accounts concerning the origins of the disturbances.

One particularly important Hai San petition preserved within the Colonial Office records presents a counter-narrative concerning the dispute. The petition alleged that upstream mining activity associated with Ghee Hin miners had interfered with water supplies connected to an earlier Hai San mining operation situated further downstream.⁷

The petition stated that:

“the water flowing from above was obstructed...”

and alleged that the resulting interference affected existing Hai San mining activity.⁸

This evidence is significant because it demonstrates that responsibility for the dispute was actively contested within the contemporaneous correspondence itself.

The question of upstream and downstream positioning would have been central to determining practical control over mining water supply. If Hai San mining operations were situated downstream from Ghee Hin-controlled areas, then later claims that Hai San miners deliberately deprived Ghee Hin operations of water become less straightforward than many retrospective summaries suggest.⁹

At present, the examined records do not appear to contain any definitive contemporaneous technical survey or adjudicative determination conclusively establishing:

- which faction occupied the superior upstream position,
- whether interference was deliberate,
- or how responsibility for escalation was ultimately determined.¹⁰

Nor do the reviewed records appear to contain any clear final report explaining the evidential basis upon which responsibility was assigned to the Hai San.¹¹ The correspondence preserves allegations, testimony, compensation demands and administrative reactions, but the documentary basis underlying the final conclusions remains unclear.

The Problem of Institutional Neutrality

Another important issue emerging from the records concerns the position occupied by British authorities within the dispute itself.¹²

The contemporaneous correspondence repeatedly referred to Ghee Hin miners involved in the dispute as British subjects recruited from Penang.¹³ At the same time, British officials were involved in:

- conducting investigations,
- receiving testimony,
- adjudicating compensation claims,
- pressuring Perak authorities,
- and determining enforcement measures relating to the dispute.¹⁴

One particularly significant passage within the correspondence stated:

"I have given judgment in favour of the members of the Ghee Hin Society..."¹⁵

Such language strongly suggests that British officials were already exercising substantial adjudicative authority within Larut despite the absence of formal British sovereignty over Perak at the time.

Nineteenth-century colonial administration frequently combined executive, diplomatic, military and quasi-judicial functions in ways that differed from later modern expectations of institutional separation and procedural neutrality. The issue raised here is therefore not necessarily one of deliberate deception, but whether overlapping institutional roles influenced evidential interpretation and the later construction of historical certainty.

British authorities were not functioning merely as detached external observers. The records instead suggest an administrative environment in which British officials simultaneously occupied investigative, adjudicative and protective roles within the broader dispute.¹⁶ Under such circumstances, later historical accounts may state Hai San responsibility with greater certainty than the surviving contemporaneous evidence itself supports.¹⁷

Conclusion

The contemporaneous Colonial Office correspondence examined in this study presents a more contested picture of the First Larut War than many later historical summaries suggest. The records preserve conflicting testimony, unresolved questions concerning upstream and downstream mining positions, and uncertainty regarding the evidential basis upon which responsibility for the dispute was ultimately assigned to the Hai San.

The correspondence also reveals that British authorities simultaneously occupied investigative, adjudicative and protective roles within the dispute while repeatedly referring to Ghee Hin miners connected to the conflict as British subjects from Penang. These overlapping institutional roles formed part of the broader evidential environment within which conclusions concerning responsibility were reached.

The surviving records provide only limited visibility into Malay administrative and legal perspectives within Larut during the disturbances of 1861–1862. The correspondence examined focuses primarily upon British officials, Chinese mining groups and compensation disputes connected to British subjects from Penang.

Taken together, the surviving contemporaneous evidence does not support the degree of certainty later historiography often assigns to sole Hai San responsibility for initiating the conflict. The surviving contemporaneous correspondence instead reveals a dispute whose evidential foundations were far less settled than later historical narratives often suggest.

Researched and authored by

Ho Siew Khui 何小駒 (Hé Xiǎojū)

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